

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Z

Zephaniah 3:14, 16; Zechariah 1:14, 17; 2:7; 8:2–3; 9:9;
Hebrews 12:22; Revelation 14:1

Zion

Zion is the Hebrew name for the mountain in Jerusalem where the temple was located (2 Samuel 5:7; see also 2 Chronicles 3:1). Over time, people began using the name *Zion* to refer to all of Jerusalem. *Zion* can refer to the real city of Jerusalem, which the Babylonians destroyed in 586 BC (see 102:13; 126:1; 137:1). Rome destroyed it again in AD 70.

Zion also means more than just a physical place. It represents God's kingdom that exists everywhere (Psalm 74:2; 76:2; 84:7; 135:21; see Isaiah 26). In this spiritual city where God lives, people trust God and do what is right and good. God does not accept evil behavior, worship of false gods, or unfair treatment of others in his city.

The prophets and poets of Israel wrote that God's city is larger than the physical city of Jerusalem. People from Judah, Israel, and all nations can become citizens of this spiritual city (see Psalm 87:5–6; Hebrews 12:22–24). *Zion* is on a high mountain at the center of God's kingdom on earth (Psalm 48:2; 99:2; 132:13). God's throne is there (9:11). Because of this, God's people direct their prayers and praise toward *Zion* (53:6; 65:1; 147:12; 149:2). They also look to *Zion* for God's salvation (14:7; 20:2; 50:2; 53:6). God chose David's family line to rule over *Zion* and establish his kingdom everywhere (2:6; 110:2).

Zion represents God's protection and blessings (Psalms 46:4–11; 48:1–14; 51:18; 128:5; 134:3). Anyone who trusts in the Lord is secure "like Mount *Zion*" (Psalm 125:1). Those who reject the Lord also reject *Zion's* security and have no future (129:5–8).

The New Testament describes Mount *Zion* as a heavenly Jerusalem, the spiritual home for people from all nations spiritually "born again" through faith in Jesus Christ (Hebrews 12:22–24; see also Galatians 4:24–26; Revelation 3:12; 21:2–4). Abraham looked forward in faith to "the city with foundations" (Hebrews 11:10). Here all people of faith in God are citizens (Hebrews 12:22–24). The Lord has no geographic limits (1 Kings 8:27). So, the true *Zion* where he lives is in the inner beings of all who worship him.

Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 5:7; 1 Kings 8:1; Psalms 14:7; 48:1–14; 50:2; 51:18; 68:16; 78:68; 87:2, 5; 125:1; 128:5; 132:13; 133:3; 135:21; 147:12; Isaiah 1:27; 2:3; 3:16–17, 26; 4:3–5; 8:18; 10:12, 24, 32; 16:1; 24:23; 29:8; 30:19; 31:4, 9; 33:20; 37:22, 32; 40:9; 41:27; 52:1–2; 60:14; 62:1; 64:10; Jeremiah 26:18; 51:35; Lamentations 2:13; Joel 2:32; 3:16–17; Amos 1:2; Obadiah 1:21; Micah 3:12; 4:2;